Final essay of
Information Systems Strategy
and Leadership-course

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1. Week 1 tasks

1.1 Infobip – Company description

The chosen information technology (IT) company is Infobip, which was officially established in 2006 and is located in Vodnjan, Croatia. The founders built an IT company what would become one of the most successful global technology companies. Today, Infobip employs more than 3700 people worldwide, with offices and teams working across all continents. Some recent sources even mention that the number of employees is more than 4000.

Infobip is a global leader in cloud communications solutions. Its platform allows companies to communicate with their customers easily through many different channels. Those channels are SMS, email, WhatsApp, Viber, and Messenger. Their goal is to make communication faster and available on the platforms customers already use every day. The company's main goal is to provide safe and reliable communication and also good system of message delivery that works well for big clients such as banks and online stores.

Over the years, Infobip has expanded its global reach. Now it connects more than seven billion mobile devices and Internet of Things (IoT) devices around the world. This wide network ensures fast and secure message delivery across many countries and regions. Infobip's services help companies to get more closer with their customers and to improve their overall customer experience. In 2020, Infobip reached huge milestone where the company was valued over one billion dollars. This achievement made Infobip the first Croatian "unicorn". (Unicorn is privately held startup company valued over one billion dollars.) Since then, Infobip has continued to grow and invest in new technologies, focusing on artificial intelligence, automation, and conversational communication tools.

Infobip also takes part in supporting the technology community through its Startup Tribe program. This helps startups by providing them with funding, mentoring, and access to Infobip's communication tools. Through this program, Infobip encourages innovation and helps smaller companies grow. The company has also partnered with technology leaders, such as Microsoft, to make SMS services available in over 100 new countries through Microsoft Azure Communication Services. To summarize everything shortly, Infobip is a great example of how a small company can become a global technology leader. It focuses on cloud communication, customer engagement, innovation and it constantly continues to expand. What makes Infobip special is not only its technology but also its vision to make communication simple and accessible for everyone. The company's success shows the power of innovation and teamwork. In future, Infobip will be keep growing and helping people and companies stay connected all around the world.

1.2 Summary of articles

a) Leadership That Gets Results

This article explains that there are different leadership styles, and that each style affects organization in different ways. From leadership perspective, it is best that the leader knows every style of leadership, because different situations demand different styles of leadership. In that case, leader can apply the style which is best suited for that situation. In the article, it is also said that emotional intelligence is tightly connected to leadership styles. Research has shown that the most successful leaders have strengths in the following emotional intelligence competencies: self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, and social skill (Goleman, 2000). It is necessity that the leader has emotional competencies so he can easily understand employees and persons who he leads. In that way, he can connect more easily to people and also, he can understand their needs and desires. In text, there are mentioned six different styles of leadership. They are the coercive style, authoritative style, affiliate style, democratic style, pacesetting style and coaching style. The coercive style is all about "Do what I say". So, it is really forced way of leadership and it demands control. There are not so many situations where it can be used except crisis, like environmental, pandemic or political crisis. In the authoritative style the leader sets the main goal, but the way of achieving it depends on person to person. The people are given the freedom to choose how they want to achieve it. The affiliate style lays on the leader who puts his people at the first place. The democratic style involves people in decision making which often slows the processes. The pacesetting leader is the one who sets high standards. For some individuals it could be motivating but often it ends up with people being overwhelmed. The last one, the coaching style focuses on developing people for the future. The only problem with this style is that it requires time and motivation.

At my home university I had course Business decision making where we were discussing what are the different ways of making decisions like group thinking, DEPLHI method, nominal group, brainstorming, AHM method and others. These methods separate an ordinary leader from an expert leader, because person as a leader needs to know what way of decision making, they should choose depending on situation they are currently in.

Personally, I find myself in affiliate leadership, because I like to put others in front instead of putting myself. I do not agree that is the best way of leading others, but at least you are having good interpersonal relations. At the end, I look at it in this way, if someday I will need help I hope that there will be person on which I can rely on.

My experiences in the group projects were that if you give people the chance to choose which task they want to do it, they will do it better and with more joy. Also, at my student job during summer, I found that if I help my working colleagues with their tasks, I could rely on their help with mine.

b) Discovering Your Authentic Leadership

The second article says that great leaders do not copy others but instead they find their own style through their life experiences. They learn about themselves by reflecting on their struggles, failures, and successes. Authentic leaders live by their own values even under pressure, and they do not need any external affirmation. They stay self-aware by having the courage to face their weaknesses

and listen to feedback. Most importantly, they focus on helping others grow into leaders, which in the end brings really good results. In the end, authentic leadership is a lifelong journey of growth and reflection that requires honesty, discipline, and dedication to serving others, creating stronger organizations and a deeper sense of personal fulfillment (George, Sims, McLean, & Mayer, 2007).

I had a course Business communication where the main point of the course was to declare which are good practices to communicate with people and how to present yourself. I have learned that people communicate not only with their words but also with their actions. It is called verbal and nonverbal communication. To be a good authentic leader you should know how to present yourself and master your communication and presentation skills.

I usually do not talk too much, I rather say less and what I meant to then saying a lot of senseless things. So, having that in mind I usually like to listen and observe other people and how do they react to different things. In that way, I can easily find what someone likes and I can understand their needs. I think that is my authentic leadership because I can connect with people only by listening to them and helping them with their needs.

I could easily connect this section with the previous one mentioned. Either if it is school group projects, working environment or any other part of life when I encounter others I just prefer to listen to people around me and if I have free time I am willing to help them with their needs. That way I can feel that I did something good and on the other hand if I need someday some help I can ask people around myself.

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2. Week 2 tasks

2.1 Leadership styles

Goleman wrote about six leadership styles. They are coercive, authoritative, affiliative, democratic, pacesetting and coaching. He says best leaders know all styles and can switch when situation changes. He also explains that emotional intelligence is very important. Things like empathy, self-awareness and social skills help leaders use right style. In my case company, Infobip, some of leaders should use authoritative style to set vision and big goals for company future. They can also use democratic style when engineers and product people discuss technical solutions or design new services. I think that coaching style is good for long term employee growth and development, especially in IT field where new skills are always needed. In crisis, like server problems or data leak, coercive style may be the most useful leadership because of its decisions that must be fast. But, in the other hand I should mention that it should not be normal way of working, because it can damage team spirit and motivation. So, good mix of all styles is probably the best for Infobip company because it keeps flexibility and also positive working climate.

In article Discovering your authentic leadership the main point was that great leaders do not copy others but instead they find their own style. These leaders must be true to values, know themselves, and empower others. I think that this is very important for Infobip because company works with sensitive client data like bank messages or personal codes. In my opinion, leaders should not hide mistakes but reflect and learn from them. They should also balance rewards like salary and bonuses with motivation like purpose and personal growth. There is an option where they could give financial rewards for good results but also allow time for employees to test new projects and ideas (like Google company). Leaders also need strong support system, human resource partners or peer groups, so they don’t lose direction when stress is high. Having this kind of support will probably help leaders in Infobip to stay grounded and act in line with their values even under pressure.

I believe that both theories are useful together and can work well in Infobip. Goleman shows that flexibility in style is necessary in global company where situations change fast. The other article shows that honesty and values are needed to build trust. If Infobip leaders combine both approaches, they can adapt to technical or business crisis. Also, in every situation they can stay ethical and in accordance with their role in the company. For example, when data security problem appear they must act fast and use coercive style, but after crisis they should use affiliative style to rebuild trust in team. This way they keep balance between results and people. Personally, I think this is not only good for business but also right way to lead. Infobip is big and global company, so it needs trust, respect and strong culture. At the end, I like idea that leadership is not only about money and results, but also about helping people and listening to them.

2.2 Summary of articles

a) Managing Organizational Change

The article Managing Organizational Change: A Philosophies of Change Approach talks about the fact that changes in organizations are not simple. Having this in mind, it cannot be understood only as a simple step by step process. Traditional models often show change as linear and controlled by leaders, but in reality change is messy, constant, and full of contradictions. Organizations are never just changing, they are also continuing at the same time, which means leaders must balance stability and innovation together. In the article it is introduced ten different "philosophies of change" to show how change can be explained from many views. These include biological, rational, institutional, resource, contingency, psychological, political, cultural, systems, and postmodern perspectives. Each philosophy highlights something important, like planning, culture, external pressures, or human emotions, but each one also has limits if used alone. For example, rational planning can give structure, but it ignores the emotional side of people. Because of this, it is suggested a multi-philosophy approach. This means that leaders should combine different perspectives and accept paradoxes instead of trying to remove them. It is explained that change is not about replacing stability, but about working with both at once. The main conclusion is that managing change is an ongoing process. Change is not linear but full of contradictions (Graetz & Smith, 2010). Leaders who use multiple views and accept uncertainty are more likely to create organizations that are adaptive, flexible, and stable.

b) Leading organizational change

In this article it is explained that managing organizational change is not only about processes or structures but mainly about people. Change influences three deep drivers of human behavior purpose, identity, and mastery. No one likes changes, but they are necessary. If changes threaten and frighten people, they will resist but if changes support them, people will engage. Leaders therefore need to connect organizational changes to employees' goals and skills. The authors also argue that change is never linear. It has no clear beginning or end, and it often feels confusing or endless. Successful change usually mixes many improvement efforts at the same time, such as customer focus, process improvement, and employee involvement. Change also needs to come both from the top (vision and structure) and from the bottom (participation and support). It is important to understand the whole process of making organizational changes. Firstly, you should understand the current situation, then define the desired state and plan, next involve others to build critical mass, and finally track and stabilize results. To deal with resistance, article introduces the TRY model (test, recalibrate, yes), which shows how people move through fear, testing, and adjustment before accepting change. Also, leaders should create safe environments for this process and provide training, coaching, and feedback. Managing change is strongly connected to people's sense of purpose, identity, and mastery (Moran & Brightman, 2000). To say it shortly, the article says that leaders must balance stability and change at the same time. Effective leaders communicate clearly, provide resources, and allow people to experiment and fail safely. They must keep repeating the purpose of change and connect it to measurable goals.

c) Connection between articles and personal life

Last year, in my first year of master's I had a course called Organizational changes and risks of digital transformation, where we were discussing how various changes can affect people in various ways. Also, what are differences between traditional and enterprise risk management and how can you separate them. ERM (Enterprise Risk Management) is approach to managing all types of risks across an organization to achieve long term stability and strategic goals. On the other side TRM (Traditional Risk Management) focuses on individual risks, usually financial or operational, and reacts to problems as they arise, without an overall view of all risks.

If I find myself someday in a leader position, I think that managing organizational change will be much harder than it seems. Changes take some time to turn from words into actions because they are often messy and full of contradictions. In my opinion organizations are still running the old way of managing changes. I found the ten philosophies of change useful because each highlights different aspects, like planning, culture, or emotions, but none works alone. To me, a multi philosophy approach makes perfect sense, because it accepts uncertainties and people emotions. It could be challenging, but if it is well done, it makes organizations flexible, adaptive, and stable.

From my experience, I can tell that I do not like big changes. For example, changes in some software like applications either mobile phone or desktop. It is always frustrating for me when I need something to do and they just changed the whole concept of how the application works. Also, I have been working at the same place for last 4 years (student summer job), and it is always interesting to see what have changed at my workplace and what is new. In this case, I like changes inside the organization because they give me some sort of feeling of progress and curiosity.

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3. Week 3 tasks

3.1 Analysis of the company facing the need for diversifying

a) Reason for change

Background - The current company has only men employees from the same country and who have same level of knowledge and education. This happened because the company only hired people from same group, like same school and same networks which led to current situation.

Current state - The company lacks diversity in every possible way. It needs diversity in people knowledge, education, age, gender, culture and so on. Current situation doesn't work because the current group of people often think alike which is not good if you want to bring something new and innovative to the company. The area that suffers the most is creativity and with it also innovation. There are so many opportunities which could lead to new and innovative ways of thinking but they are missed because of the lack of creativity.

Risks of not taking action - In future, the company could face different kinds of problems like its products could become irrelevant or they could lack variety and new creative solutions. That could lead to very big impact on company business systems like losing customers because of lack of trust in the company itself. With that in mind the company is losing its part in market share.

Benefits of taking actions - It is not easy to take actions, but they are necessary. If the company wants to rebuild itself and also to increase its business it needs to diversify. There are numerous benefits which can happen by diversifying such as better and new products, gaining recognition and trust among customers. In this way, company can have bigger impact not only for itself but also for the whole community. It is very likely that new jobs will open and people will be happier at their working place.

b) Behavioral change

What behaviors need to change - At the management level, hiring managers must move away from relying only on familiar networks and candidates. Instead, they should actively seek out people from different genders, countries, and study backgrounds. At the team level, employees need to adopt a more open mindset, welcoming new colleagues who may bring different perspectives, ways of working, or cultural habits. Recruitment panels need to start hiring people who have different skills and potential, and are different from the current group.

What does success look like and how is measured - Success will not be achieved overnight, but the company can define what it looks like in clear, measurable ways. A successful outcome means that company no longer looks uniform but instead has visible diversity in gender, nationality, age, and academic background. Progress can be tracked through data such as the percentage of women in the workforce and the share of employees from different countries. Success should also be reflected in employee surveys showing that people feel included, respected, and valued.

What knowledge, skills and abilities are needed to ensure new behaviors - To make these changes possible, employees and managers will need new knowledge and skills. For example, employees will benefit from training in cross-cultural collaboration and inclusive communication. These skills will allow the company to function effectively as it becomes more diverse.

What systems and tools are needed to support the behavior change - Recruitment needs to be expanded so that the company can reach a wider group of people like partnerships with various universities,

joining networks that support women in technology. Also, job descriptions must be rewritten to highlight the value of diverse skills and experiences.

What new policies, procedures and processes are needed to support the behavior change – The company should introduce wide diversity goals and require diverse hiring panels. These structural changes will help make fairer and more inclusive hiring decisions.

What training is needed to support the behavior change - This includes workshops on unconscious bias, inclusive leadership, and teamwork between people from different countries. Employees with these practical skills and knowledge should be ready to collaborate in more diverse teams.

What organizational assistance is available to emotionally support the employee – The company can create mentorship programs that connect different groups with senior colleagues and provide safe spaces where concerns can be spoken. These measures will help new hires feel welcomed and also help current employees adjust to the change.

What reinforcements/consequences need to be in place to sustain behavior change - Leaders should be recognized and rewarded for their effort. Also, hiring practices should be monitored more regularly. At the same time, achievements such as reaching diversity in the company should be celebrated across the company to show that these efforts matter and are making a difference.

3.2 Summary of articles

a) Blue Ocean Strategy

The first article talks about Blue Ocean Strategy. The idea is that companies should not fight in crowded markets (red oceans), but instead create new markets (blue oceans) where there is no competition. In practice, companies should give customers something new and different while also keeping costs low. Reduce your costs while also offering customers more value (Kim & Mauborgne, 2004). The main characteristics of red ocean strategy is that companies are competing in the existing market where demand is limited. Also, because of so many companies there, products become more similar and they look alike. On the opposite side, blue ocean strategy creates new values and customers demand. Companies grow faster and with no competition. Often, they offer products that already exist but in a smarter way. In my opinion, this is good because companies can grow by making technology easier and more useful for people.

I selected this article because we already have mentioned this topic in my home university except we weren't going deep into this topic. I found it interesting to read and to deepen my knowledge on this topic.

Most important point in my opinion, is that companies do not always need to fight with competitors in the same market. Instead, they can grow faster and earn more if they create new markets where there is no competition. This is important because in crowded markets profits are low and products are very similar. Another thing which I should mention is that companies can give more value to customers and keep costs low. They do not always need new technology. Often, they just need to use what already exists but in a better way.

Most important points from software/high-tech business view are that success is not only about inventing new technology. Often, technology already exists, but companies are reaching there when

they make it easier, cheaper, and more useful for customers. Here are some examples. eBay is an online marketplace where people can buy and sell all kinds of products, from clothes to electronics, cars and whatever comes to your mind. eBay created the online auction market, which did not exist before which perfectly fits the blue ocean idea. Also, there is another example where Dell, American technology company which sells IT products and services, sold computers directly to customers and let them customize online. At the end, this created a new way of buying computers.

b) Turning Great Strategy into Great Performance

In this article it is pointed out that most companies do not reach the full value of their strategies. They often lose results because of poor planning or weak execution. Companies typically realize only about 60% of their strategies' potential value because of defects and breakdowns in planning and execution (Mankins & Steele, 2005). Successful companies should keep their strategies simple and clear. It is important that companies often check if their assumptions are realistic and that they use the same language and framework across the whole company. It is also said that companies should decide about resources early and set clear priorities so they can watch progress all the time and make changes when needed. Last thing pointed out is companies should hire, train, and reward good managers. By doing this, companies can achieve much better results and build a strong culture of success.

I chose this article because personally I think that there is really strong connection between strategy and performance. If someone has the best strategy in the world, it doesn't mean that he will have the best performance. Everything depends on clear communication and cooperation between leaders, managers and employes.

The most important points in this article are that most companies fail to get full value from their strategies. The reason is usually poor planning, unclear goals, or weak execution. Also, it is mentioned seven rule principles that help close this gap: keep the strategy simple, test your assumptions, use a common language, decide about resources early, set clear priorities, monitor progress all the time, and hire and reward the right people. (Mankins & Steele, 2005) These rules are important because they make sure everyone in the company understands the plan, works on the right things, and adjusts quickly when problems arise.

Most important point from software/hightech business point in this article is that todays world is changing really fast, and so do technologies and other innovations. As technology advances, customers need and demand are also changing in accordance with innovations. I would like to mention what is, from my perspective, the most crucial parts of modern leadership. It is clear and simple strategy, monitoring progress constantly and having some sort of vision. If the strategy is too complex, employes won't know what to focus on, so with clear direction it is easier to avoid confusion. Constantly monitoring projects makes them possible to adapt fast when something doesn't work. I should also mention that it is important to have some sort of reward for most successful employees which is important for the development of a good organizational climate.

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4. Week 4 tasks

4.1 Porter's five competitive forces

Bargaining power of buyers - Infobip's buyers are businesses such as banks, e-commerce companies, and service providers that need reliable communication with their customers. Today, buyers have many choices in market, as there are other large global companies like Twilio. This gives buyers power to choose from different prices and more affordable options. However, switching from one communication platform to another can be complex. For this reason, buyers have moderate power. They can compare prices and quality but viewed over a longer period reliability and trust actually matter more.

Bargaining power of suppliers – so, Infobip depends on several suppliers, such as mobile network operators and messaging app platforms like WhatsApp and Viber. These suppliers are having significant role, because the company must rely on them so it can deliver its services. Here is some example, if a messaging platform changes its rules or prices, Infobip must adapt to it. Overall, the bargaining power of suppliers is moderate to high, since Infobip can't operate without these connections with suppliers.

Threat of substitute products or services - The main need for Infobip to fulfil is fast and reliable communication. There are some substitutes for this, such as traditional advertising, call centers, or using social media pages to talk to customers. But there is some problems, these options are often slower, less personal, and harder to use on a large scale. For example, posting on social media does not guarantee that the message will reach the customer directly. Infobip's services are designed to deliver messages quickly and securely to each customer. Because of this, substitutes exist, but they are not very strong alternatives. The threat of substitutes is low to moderate.

Threat of new entrants - Starting a company like Infobip is not that easy. New competitors would need good technology, many skilled workers, and global partnerships with mobile operators. This requires a lot of money and time. Because of this, the barriers to entry are high, and only a few companies can reach the same level as Infobip. Still, new technologies such as AI or new digital platforms could bring competition in the future. For now, the threat of new entrants is low to moderate.

Rivalry among existing competitors - Infobip faces strong competition from other global companies like Twilio and Vonage. These companies offer similar services and have same business customers. Rivalry is intense because many companies are competing on price, quality, and new features. To follow competition, Infobip must keep improving its services, adding new communication channels, and providing good customer support. The rivalry in this field is high, but Infobip has already built a strong presence with wide service offering.

4.2 Summary of articles

a) Getting IT right

The article explains why many companies struggle with information technology and how they can improve it. It is also said that IT is often complicated, expensive, and disconnected from business goals, which leads to poor results. From what I have read, IT success depends less on technology itself and more on leadership, organization, and strategy. There are three key principles discussed in the article. A long term IT renewal plan connected to the corporate strategy, a simplified unifying corporate technology platform, and a highly functional, performance oriented IT organization. The main message is that companies should not treat IT as an isolated technical department but as core business function.

Looking from a software or high-tech company perspective this is super important, since technology is everywhere. Without clear leadership from managers, projects often fail or just waste money. I think the key message is that managers must take responsibility and not just leave everything to the IT department. To say it simply, IT strategy must be also a part of business strategy.

When I connect this with my studies, I can see a lot of connections. In information security we already discussed trade offs between privacy, security, cost and convenience, and the article says exactly the same thing. Also, in project management classes we learned that setting clear priorities and responsibilities is the best way to make big IT systems like ERP or CRM successful. From my work experience, even if it is not directly in IT, I can also understand this. I worked during summers in an aquarium, and in a shoe and diving equipment shop. Even in those places, I saw how IT systems are used for tickets, for payments and for tracking products. Sometimes the systems were slow or not really well connected, and that made problems both for workers and for customers. It made me realize that if managers don't care enough about IT, then the employees are the ones who suffer and customers too. This fits the article very well because IT should not be left alone, it needs leadership and planning. So for me, the most important thing to remember is that IT decisions must always be connected with business strategy, and managers must take responsibility. This actually makes the difference between wasting money on technology and actually getting value from it.

b) Six IT decisions

The article explains why top managers must actively make certain IT decisions instead of leaving them to the IT department. It is mentioned that many executives feel unsure about technology, but if they avoid responsibility, companies waste money and miss opportunities. In the article there are six critical decisions which are highlighted. How much to spend on IT explains how budgets should be connected to business strategy and not just industry averages. Following with which business processes get IT funding which says that leaders must set priorities and avoid overwhelming IT with too many projects. The section which IT capabilities must be companywide describes that managers must balance standardization with business unit flexibility. Next one is how good IT services should be which explains choices about reliability, speed, and accessibility and how they must reflect business needs and costs. The fifth one is what security and privacy risks to accept. Security, like reliability and responsiveness, is a feature of IT systems that requires companies to weigh the level of protection they want against the amount they are willing to spend (Ross & Weill, 2002). It explains that leaders should

measure protection against convenience and cost. The last one is about who is accountable if IT fails. It is not just IT but also business managers, who must take responsibility for realizing business value. At the end, I can tell that the main message is that IT decisions should be also business decisions.

From the perspective of a software or high-tech company, this is very interesting thing to observe. If you only buy new systems without thinking about how they work together or how they support company goals, you just end up wasting money. But if you think in the long term and keep systems simple and connected, then IT becomes a strength.

I can link this to my studies experience. In project management we often learned that planning and execution are as important as technology itself. In security classes too, we saw that technology alone is not enough without proper organization and culture. From my summer jobs, when I worked in the aquarium, the ticket system sometimes didn't work properly and customers had to wait. In the diving equipment shop, some items were not in the system so we had to do things by hand. These problems were not really about the technology itself, but more because there was no long term plan or good organization of the IT systems. At the end, from all that I have learned, I could easily say that IT success comes from leadership and good planning and not just from having the newest technology.

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5. Week 5 tasks

5.1 Connecting IT with business strategies

The two articles which were discussed in previous week talk about how IT should be connected to business strategy. At Infobip, IT is not just a support function. It is the core of the business. The company provides cloud communication solutions to businesses around the world, enabling them to send messages through SMS, email, voice, and chat apps like WhatsApp or Viber. This means that every IT decision directly affects how well Infobip can serve its customers. From Getting IT Right article, the main message is that IT success depends on leadership, planning, and integration with business goals. For Infobip, this means that IT decisions cannot be left only to the technical teams. The management must take responsibility for IT strategy and ensure it aligns with the company's goals. For example, if the company wants to expand its messaging platform for banks, the IT roadmap should focus on security, reliability, and speed. This way, technology investments will support the business strategy, not just add cost. A clear long term IT plan will also help Infobip manage new projects and innovations in a coordinated way.

Another important point from this article is the need for a unified technology platform. Infobip has thousands of employees working globally, and many teams use different tools and systems. Standardizing platforms for project management, communication, and system monitoring would make collaboration easier. It would also reduce mistakes and delays caused by incompatible systems. Simplifying IT in this way helps both employees and customers because the services will be more reliable and consistent.

The other article Six IT Decisions emphasizes that managers must make six critical IT choices. At Infobip, the most important ones are deciding how much to spend on IT, which business processes get IT funding, and what security risks to accept. Because the company handles large volumes of customer messages, spending on reliable servers, fast networks, and secure systems is essential. Managers must prioritize projects that improve customer experience, such as faster message delivery or new communication channels. Security is also critical, especially for clients like banks. Infobip must decide the level of protection it provides while considering costs and performance. These decisions must be made by leadership, not just IT teams, to make sure business value is realized.

Finally, both articles stress accountability. At Infobip, IT failures are not only technical problems. Managers and project leaders share responsibility for ensuring systems meet business goals. This helps create a culture where IT is seen as a strategic asset, not just a technical service. In my opinion, applying these ideas in Infobip means creating a clear IT roadmap, prioritizing projects based on business value, and ensuring strong security. By doing this, Infobip can deliver reliable, fast, and secure communication solutions to customers worldwide.

5.2 Summary of articles

The Concept of Ba: Building a Foundation for Knowledge Creation, and Managing Your Mission-Critical Knowledge, both explore how organizations can approach knowledge as a core strategic asset.

From first article, the central idea is the concept of Ba. Ba can be explained as a shared space physical, virtual, or mental, where knowledge is created and used. It says that knowledge is not static information stored in databases but it is created through human interaction. Leaders must therefore design not only technical systems but also environments that enable collaboration and knowledge sharing. Also, the article highlights that knowledge is dynamic and constantly evolving. It moves through cycles, transforming tacit insights into explicit forms and back again. This challenges the common belief that databases or analytics alone are enough. The main message which should be told is that technology should support human interaction rather than replace it.

From the second article I found quite interesting that the key lesson is the importance of identifying and managing mission critical knowledge. It is warn against focusing only on big data while ignoring the deeper knowledge assets that drive competitive advantage. The method of mapping knowledge could be presented as two dimensions. Tacit versus explicit and proprietary versus widespread. It helps companies see which knowledge matters most, which should be shared, and which should remain protected. For IT strategy, this is essential because it allows leaders to concentrate resources on knowledge that directly supports the company's mission. For example, a high-tech company specializing in cybersecurity must ensure that expertise in encryption and system defense is identified, strengthened, and spread internally. At the same time, less critical knowledge could be shared externally to build partnerships or create new revenue streams.

To summarize both articles I can say that knowledge is both contextual and strategic. First article shows how knowledge emerges in the right environments, while second one provides a framework for mapping and managing it. For high tech companies, combining these views means building spaces for innovation while also protecting and leveraging critical knowledge.

Personal experience:

These insights connect directly to my studies in informatics at the Faculty of Organization and Informatics. During my education, I learned both technical and managerial aspects of information systems. In courses such as "Information Systems Security," we studied encryption and risk management. This explicit, codified knowledge is important, but Nonaka's concept of Ba reminds me that security also depends on tacit knowledge: user awareness, intuition of experts, and collaboration among teams. Meanwhile, Ihrig and MacMillan's framework highlights that such knowledge must be recognized as mission critical and protected as part of IT strategy. In theoretical courses such as "Discrete Structures" and "Graph Theory," I learned abstract mathematical principles. At first, they seemed detached from real world practice, but later I realized that they provide a foundation for network design, algorithms, and data analysis. Linking to the articles, this shows how knowledge can be contextualized. Abstract theories become valuable assets when applied in the right context. This is the same process described by Nonaka and by Ihrig and MacMillan when they explain how knowledge evolves and creates value.

My work experience also provides practical connections. When I worked as an aquarist in an aquarium, I dealt with routines of cleaning, maintaining equipment, and ensuring the well-being of fish. Much of this knowledge was tacit, gained through practice rather than manuals. This aligns with Nonaka's idea of tacit knowledge and Ba, as the aquarium served as a shared space where colleagues exchanged tips and experience. When I worked in a shoe and diving equipment store, I experienced the importance of customer interaction and product knowledge. This shows how both technical knowledge (about diving gear) and soft knowledge (about customer needs) are mission critical in retail. Ihrig and MacMillan emphasize that such soft skills can be as strategic as technical expertise.

Through these experiences, I can tell that knowledge is not only stored in documents or systems but is embedded in people, routines, and environments. This connects directly to the two articles. First article shows the need to create environments for sharing, and second one demonstrate how to strategically manage knowledge assets. For my future work in IT, these lessons mean that I must focus not only on technology but also on people, processes, and strategy. The two articles provide complementary insights into the role of knowledge in organizations. Nonaka's concept of Ba emphasizes the dynamic and contextual nature of knowledge creation, while Ihrig and MacMillan stress the need to identify and manage mission-critical knowledge assets. From the perspective of IT strategy in software and high-tech companies, these lessons are central because they ensure that technology supports collaboration, that critical knowledge is protected, and that resources are invested wisely. Connecting these lessons with my studies and work experience, I see that knowledge management is both theoretical and practical. It applies not only in IT but also in areas as diverse as aquariums and retail stores. In every context, success depends on understanding which knowledge matters most, how it is created and shared, and how it can be turned into value.

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6. Week 6 tasks

6.1 Knowledge management strategy

a) Knowledge management approach: Binney's KM Spectrum

I personally believe that knowledge is the most valuable resource that company can have. Since Infobip operates globally and provides complex cloud communication solutions, knowledge is essential for success of company because it can create new solutions and innovations. After reviewing different approaches, I decided that Binney's knowledge management Spectrum best fits company's overall business strategy. This model allows to connect technology with people and innovation goals. Also, Binney's KM Spectrum supports Infobip's core business because it covers several layers of knowledge activities, from analytical knowledge (data and information systems) to process improvement and innovation. Business usually relies on technology, but at the same time, it depends on people sharing their skills and ideas across teams in different parts of the world. I chose Binney's model because it helps manage knowledge. Knowledge in Infobip exists in databases, documentation, software systems, and also employees and experience.

b) Content of the strategy:

Important knowledge - For Infobip, important knowledge includes everything related to technology, products and customer needs. Technical knowledge about cloud architecture and communication channels is necessary for developing and maintaining platform. Market and customer knowledge help design products for different customers.
Critical knowledge – I think that the most critical knowledge of Infobip is about data security and system reliability. Since Infobip handles sensitive data for clients worldwide, it is important to keep this type of knowledge updated and protected. In that way the company can build up trust and compliance.
Information - Most of information is stored in internal databases, CRM tools, and project management systems such as Jira and Confluence. Knowledge is also shared through teamwork and online meetings where employees exchange their experiences and ideas.
Tools, methods and technologies - Technologies like business intelligence systems and data analytics programs serve as a way to access and share information. Automation and increasing presence of AI help analyze customer data, while communication tools like Slack support daily activities.
Knowledge the company needs to make decisions - For decision making, Infobip depends on a mix of analytical data and employee various experiences. Strategic decisions use market research and customer data. Technical decisions rely more on engineers and developers knowledge.
Role of tacit knowledge - Tacit knowledge is important for Infobip because it drives innovation. Teams learn from each other, share insights, and create new solutions through collaboration. This kind of knowledge is what helps company to stay creative and competitive.

To summarize it shortly, I think that chosen approach (Binney's Knowledge Management Spectrum) suits really good to company strategy. By connecting technology with human experience, it helps Infobip achieve its main goal and is to deliver secure, fast, and personalized communication to customers around the world.

6.2 Summary of articles

a) From Software Product Lines to Software Ecosystems

The authors of this article explain how software companies are moving from using software product lines inside their organizations to creating software ecosystems that include external partners and developers. A software product line allows a company to reuse parts of its software across many products. This makes development faster, cheaper, and more consistent. However, companies often reach a point where the benefits of internal reuse are not enough. They start to open their platforms to outside contributors. When they do this, they move from a closed product line to an open ecosystem. The article also describes why this change happens. One reason is that companies cannot develop all the features their customers want within a reasonable time and budget. By opening their platforms, they let outside developers create extra functions and services. This allows the company to satisfy more users without increasing its own workload. Another reason is that customers today expect personalized software. They want applications that fit their individual needs. Allowing third party developers to add extensions or plugins helps meet those expectations. This process of mass customization gives users more control and makes the platform more valuable.

Authors also describe that companies benefit in several ways from ecosystems. They can increase the value of their main products and make it harder for customers to switch to competitors. They can also share the cost of developing and maintaining new features with their partners. As a result, the company can grow its market faster and stay competitive for longer.

There is three main types of ecosystems. The first is operating system centric, where third party developers build software for an operating system, such as Windows, Linux, or Android. The second is application centric, where developers create extensions or applications for a specific platform, such as Facebook. The third type is end user programming ecosystems, where people who are not programing can build their own simple applications, such as in Excel. Each ecosystem type has its own benefits and challenges. Operating system ecosystems are powerful because they attract many developers and users. The downside is that they must deal with hardware diversity and compatibility issues. Application ecosystems grow quickly when they have a large user base, but they must balance the needs of both users and developers. End user ecosystems encourage creativity but are limited to simpler use cases. The article also discusses how companies can move from a product line to an ecosystem. They must decide how open they want their platform to be. A directed approach means selecting specific partners and managing them closely. An undirected approach means allowing anyone to build on the platform without restrictions. Most companies use a mix of both. Overall, the first article shows that software ecosystems represent a evolution of product lines. It mentions collaboration, innovation and creating more value for users.

b) The Orchestrator's Partner Management Framework for Software Ecosystems

The second article focuses on how companies that manage software ecosystems (orchestrators) can build and maintain strong relationships with their partners. In a software ecosystem, there are many actors, such as organizations that produce software, customers, and platform owners. The orchestrator is responsible for connecting everyone, cooperation, and keeping the ecosystem healthy. It is explained that many orchestrators face difficulties in managing their partners effectively. They often do not have the right tools or clear strategies to attract and retain partners. As a result, they may lose contributors and slow down innovation. To solve this problem, the article introduces a structured model called the Software Ecosystem Partner Management Framework (SECO-PMF). This framework helps orchestrators understand, evaluate, and improve their partner management practices.

The framework was developed using a research method called design science. This means the authors combined theory from academic literature with practical data from real companies. They reviewed existing studies on ecosystems and conducted five detailed case studies. These case studies included companies of different sizes and levels of maturity, which made it possible to test how well the framework worked in different conditions. The SECO-PMF identifies three main components of partner management which are partner management activities, ecosystem enablers and partner goals. Partner management activities describe the actions that orchestrators take to work with partners, such as creating developer programs or offering technical support. Ecosystem enablers explain the tools and resources that help partners succeed, such as documentation, training, or marketing support. At the end, partner goals say what partners want to achieve, for example earning profit or reaching more customers.

This framework also shows how enablers help partners reach their goals. For example, if an orchestrator provides clear documentation, partners can build and release applications faster. The research also shows that a healthy software ecosystem depends on trust and balanced relationships. Orchestrators must create value not only for themselves but also for their partners. When orchestrators invest in shared success, or shared revenue models then the ecosystem grows stronger.

In the article it is said that bad governance can destroy an ecosystem, like in example where platform owners failed to keep partner support. Good governance, on the other hand, creates productivity and innovation. Productivity measures how much value is created from the ecosystem activities. Robustness refers to the ability of the ecosystem to survive over time. Niche creation measures the system ability to generate new ideas and specialized markets.

The article concludes that successful ecosystems depend on cooperation between all actors. Orchestrators should focus on building good relationships, creating good value distribution, and encouraging innovation. Also, managing partners is not just an administrative task, it is also a core part of maintaining ecosystem.

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7. Week 7 tasks

7.1 Partner goals

In software ecosystems, many companies work together to create value. Each company joins for a different reason. In the article by van Vulpen et al., Table 4 shows five main partner goals. They are customer access, customer demand, platform integration, business expansion, and cost reduction. These goals describe why partners want to join or stay in an ecosystem. In my opinion, several of these goals fit very well with the company Infobip. Infobip works with many partners, such as banks, online shops, and software developers, so it is part of a large software ecosystem.

The first goal from the table that fits Infobip is platform integration. Many companies that use Infobip want to connect their systems directly with Infobip's platform. For example, a bank might want to automatically send verification codes through Infobip's services. This connection allows the partner to use Infobip's technology without building it themselves. I think this is one of the biggest reasons why companies join Infobip's ecosystem. It saves them time and gives them reliable tools for communication. It also helps Infobip because more integrations usually mean more usage of its platform and because of that also stronger relationships with partners.

The second goal is business expansion. By joining Infobip's ecosystem, partners can grow their business and reach new markets. For example, a small software company that integrates with Infobip can now offer global messaging or notification services to its customers. This adds value to their own product and helps them compete with larger companies. On the other side, Infobip also expands its business through these partners. I believe this is the best situation for both sides because partners grow their business and Infobip gets more recognition around the world.

Another goal that matches Infobip is customer access. Many partners want to reach more customers, and Infobip already has a large base of clients. By being part of Infobip's network, smaller companies can get access to these customers more easily. For example, a new messaging app or a local telecom provider could become a partner to reach global users. In my opinion, this goal shows that companies can grow faster together than they could on their own.

I can also see how cost reduction is connected to Infobip, but maybe less directly. Building and maintaining a global communication system is expensive. By using Infobip's cloud platform, partners save money because they do not need to create their own infrastructure. They also benefit from Infobip's experience and security systems. This allows them to focus on their main business instead of technical details. I think this is especially helpful for smaller or new companies that cannot afford big investments.

Ethical issues: Infobip operates with sensitive user data, such as personal messages and security codes. This means that data privacy and protection are extremely important. Infobip and its partners must follow rules, like the GDPR in Europe, to make sure that all communication stays safe and private. I think this is not only a legal requirement but also a moral. Users must be able to trust that their information will not be used for wrong purposes. Another ethical question is fairness. Infobip should treat all partners equally and it should clearly explain prices and data policies. This helps build trust among all of partners.

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8. Summary of learning

During this course, I learned how information systems and leadership are connected together and they are really important for organizations and their success. I understood that IT is not only a technical part of a company but also a strategic asset that must support business goals. Leadership is important in managing people, changes, and knowledge. On a higher level, I learned how strategy, leadership, and technology together shape company success. I was able to connect theories from this course with my previous studies, such as risk management, information security, and organizational change. This helped me see how knowledge from different areas can be combined in real contexts. Personally, I also learned about the importance of authentic and flexible leadership, teamwork, and knowledge sharing. I realized that leadership is not just about authority but about understanding people, trust and innovation. This course gave me a better understanding of how IT strategy is connected with leadership and human factors which take big part in creating success and additional values for companies.